

Tempera and oil paints

Made from powdered pigment mixed with egg yolk, tempera was used for ancient and medieval paintings and for a large part of the Italian Renaissance. As it could not be stored and dried rapidly, artists had to mix small amounts and paint small areas at a time. The stiff consistency made blending difficult, and artists painted in layers. Then in the Low Countries during the 15th century, painters became more interested in describing the world around them in realistic detail and they discovered that mixing pigment with linseed or poppy oil rather than egg was more forgiving. Oil paint dried more slowly than tempera, so it could be pushed around and blended easily. It could also be applied in glazes or thin layers, and by creating brilliant colours, tonal contrasts, and a translucent sheen, it proved excellent for the depiction of a host of different textures.

As artists travelled between the Netherlands and southern Europe, the techniques of oil painting spread, and by the 16th century it was the major painting medium throughout Europe.



Fra Lippi, *Madonna and Child with Angels* (tempera on panel), c.1455